

SUBURBAN DREAMTIME ON SHOW

By LESLEYANN HAWTHORNE

It is Sunday afternoon on the dream-home circuit. We have left our car in the parking lot, and we enter Displaysville.

Neat salesmen with gravel-crunching shoes pop up beside us. The place has many houses, surrounded by little wire fences. It is in fact a maze that directs your feet first through the registered office (with its visual displays, its large desk, its offer of plans, prices, consultation) into House A.

There are, of course, Houses B, C, and D nearby. But the wire doesn't permit a freedom of choice. You start at one, and are routed through to the others.

House A is large, slick, and elegantly furnished. It has walls of mirrors, to double the sense of space. It has fine carpets, two bathrooms, beamed ceilings, and a sudden sense of light. Little labels adhering to the surface of most of the things that give it charm tell you DECORATOR ITEM ONLY, which means "not included". That cuts out the carpets, the tiles, the mirrors, the cupboard doors, the heater, the lights, the dishwasher, and other extras.

You proceed to House B. This is the budget version, the rooms contracted, the corridors pinched, with a more fanatical use of mirrors. Standing in the living-room, you can see yourself flashed back from a dozen angles. Even in the eating-nook squeezed to the side of the kitchen, you find yourself relentlessly mirrored. VISTAS OF LIGHT! crows the pamphlet. LOSE YOURSELF IN THE CHARM AND ELEGANCE OF THIS EXCEPTIONAL HOME!

With the ambler ahead you jostle hips in the passage that takes you into the bedroom side of the house. Here is the master-suite, with its Sheridan-quilted bed, the vast walk-in wardrobe, and the natty en suite where you can chat in connubial comfort while someone sits on the loo.

Farther down the corridor are bedrooms two and three — comparatively dark and poky with a grim outlook, separated from mother and father by a cupboard-size room called Study or Parents' Retreat.

It is assumed that parents will do a lot of retreating, because this room recurs in spite of the fact that Houses A, C and D offer incredibly separate zoning. Each has different diningrooms, living-rooms and bathrooms for parents and children. In some instances the kids are stowed a whole wing away. If a rumpus-room is included, you have purchased an

entire set of three living centres. With luck, you need not encounter your children once in a day!

The stragglers with their shorts, their jeans, their pushers, are pursuing elegant settings for their lives. For me it is a re-run. I hit the dream-home circuit prematurely when I was 16. My boyfriend was older than I, consumed with lust and honorable intentions. It was the '60s, but he was old-fashioned. He liked the passion music of a decade before. He determined to marry me and site me on a quarter-acre block. He would go out to work, then return to pay conjugal visits.

"For wives should always be lovers too. Run to his arms the moment he comes home to you. He's almost here...!"

Every Sunday he put my friendship ring on my left hand, and we toured the circuit. We went to Glen Waverley, which was a display home desert. With thousands of other couples we marched hand-in-hand through the box-like bedrooms, the kitchens with breakfast bars, the unspeakable privacy of the first en suite.

I was caught between intolerable excitement, and a sense of panic. It was a world of chain-smoking salesmen, barren new gardens, a life compelled by three bedrooms, two bathrooms, and a step-down livingroom that was newer than new.

I could never believe in it enough. Many of those weekends we stayed over with Mandy and Neil, my prospective in-laws, who were battling it out in the suburbs.

They were marooned in an L-shaped dream home by a concrete drive with chopped-down gum-trees. The house was bare inside because starting out right had left them ruthlessly mortgaged. As one unplanned pregnancy followed another, Neil took two jobs and came home wiped-out late at night. Mandy prepared meal after meal of spaghetti in her dream-home kitchen. She despised Neil for not supporting her and the kids and the mortgage. He felt a martyr to her fecundity. It was not an inducement to suburban life.

Four years later I left it. It is a glossy Sunday afternoon, and now I'm part of a different couple. We are back on the dream-home circuit together, for living in Melbourne means embracing the suburbs. As much as football, this is a local ritual, a weekend way of life. We drive up Wellington Road to Rowville to the start of the outer suburbs. In a way the place is irrelevant.

Go to any edge of Melbourne — Altona Gate, Kellor Downs, Endeavour Hills, Patterson Lakes. That's where the land is cheap, that's where the dream homes are selling. You pass neat new industry, electric pylons in the distance, kids riding bicycles over rough green meadows.

Turning right at Stud Road we see a sign, The Lakes. The logo shows a seagull over waves and there are 20 display homes open. We go first to South Village, turning into Superior Avenue past twin-garage houses of red brick, brown brick, speckled brick and wood. We park next to a lake-access home, walking across an empty site, a quarter acre filled with daisies.

The Dandenongs are in the background and the lakes look pretty though the houses don't — yet. There is wild fun, hoots of distant laughter from the common-land across the water. At the East Village landing kids are diving, swimming, and sailing model yachts. Some people have bought a lifestyle already. Their houses are lived in. They have clothes hanging from the line to prove it.

We go first to Kolders Homes — The Retreat, The Woodland, The Homestead, and The Haven. Women don't like seclusion in the suburbs, said a recent article. Men do, because they are mostly absent. Perhaps they look for cosy ovens in the name.

A man and a woman sit in an office at separate desks, in a great weight of silence. They are fixed in front of sample rows of bricks, taps and Laminex. The woman has scarlet lips, a composed face and a clock-watching eye. We part them to enter The Haven, which is dove-grey and mauve everywhere, as if color inspiration climaxed in the choice of taps.

The lounge room is sunken, with a view of the lake that will almost certainly be built out. A rail bisects from the diningroom, so that you cannot fall down. A pouter pigeon is the dominant ornament.

We walk through, discovering that the place has cool, clear lines and an obsessive homogeneity. We peer through the grey kitchen to a grey pergola, grey paving, and a very grey barbecue. We move to the billiardroom, which has a mauve bar with mauve rattan furniture, not to mention a mauve and grey billiard table.

You get my trend? Across the road are Executive Homes, the target of an Indian family — three young women in bright saris tailing a skinny man. She forgets for the moment that you pay for all this, then move —



the warning sternly — though it's nothing to the Glenville statement farther up the hill. We look at the plans, which are remarkably similar. Billiards are in. I have a vision of people playing them frantically throughout the outer suburbs.

We are about to see COLONIAL CHARM DESIGNED TO BLEND WITH BRIGHT OPEN LIVING AREAS. In fact "colonial charm" means little more than paneled windows. There is supposed to be a private courtyard too; from what we can see it is the hollow in the L-shape, closed in by a little garden.

Lorna Green, in her fifties and from Dandenong, is having a good look through The Sunnybrook. She has a soft, comfortable body, and wears a sensible drip-dry frock. She and her husband do the rounds of the display homes often, seeing what they'd one day hoped to buy. Their kids have grown up and gone now, their fibro house is good enough, and in a sense the dream has passed. But she admires still, and she thinks the homes are lovely. They are an illustrated 'Home Beautiful'. They keep her up with real suburban chic.

She walks through the master bedroom overlooking a private fern garden. She goes to the nursery next door, and the bathroom with flatter light. In that mirror you look as if you could afford the house, as if you might even be the type to buy it.

There are immaculate fittings, a flawless bath and shower that could never imaginably be dirty. And it seems cheap, almost cheap at the price! \$53,000 for the house, \$70,000 more for land on the lake, \$45,000 for land across the road.

She forgets for the moment that you pay for all this, then move — like Mandy and Neil — into a barren empty house. Just now it is the dream that possesses her. Muzak pipes softly through the intercom to each bedroom. There is a wonderful long lean laundry at the back of the house, so absurdly sited that it commands the best view. There are kids running barefoot around the lake path. "Oh," says Lorna Green, staring out of the window. "It's a beautiful place here, look at the planning! Look at the lake there! Oh, what it would be like to live here!"

At least half the people looking are in late middle-age, like Lorna. Many of them are mooning over something they will never buy. Others have come more practically, to bank-roll their grown-up children.

We follow a group up the path to Glenville, but the doors are locked. A large yellow sign says: THANK YOU FOR CALLING. SMOKING AND EATING ARE PROHIBITED IN THIS DISPLAY HOME.

CHILDREN ENTERING MUST BE UNDER STRICT ADULT CONTROL. ELECTRONIC BURGLAR ALARMS ARE FITTED TO THIS HOME. LEGAL ACTION WILL BE TAKEN AGAINST ANYONE WHO COPIES ALL OR ANY PART OF THIS HOME.

It is good to feel welcome. We reverse down Mississippi Close, driving to East Village past the landing stage with the shrieking and splashing. We enter The Chardonnay, which you get for \$60,950 (your land) or \$4100 full deposit.

Entry is via a fleur-de-lis spear fence, a daisy garden, and a fountain with goldfish on a very small scale. This house works by starting you. The fountain is in fact a clue.

As you walk the narrow corridors to the master bedroom you hear a loud swishing that suggests a washing machine is near. But no! In the en suite — a most extravagant bathroom — there is a heart-shaped spa that is swirling and bubbling! It might take two of you at a pinch for frolics, or possibly drown a very small child. It is drawing a buzz of acclamation.

"Jeeze!" says Julie coming up the passage with Gary, whom she might marry. "It's hot up here! Jeeze! Get a look at that!" The house is small, but offers unsuspected luxuries. Even in the children's bathroom there are twin basins. A bar in the living-room has a sink with a brass tap, and decorative Zulu head mounted on a platter. People passing through seem truly enthralled. "This is a beautiful place!" say

barefooted kids, running through it, giggling.

"Got your parents with you?" asks the salesman coming up behind them.

"Oh yeah!" say the kids. They run out, having done a quick check. You suspect they belong to the estate, but that in their opinion the estate belongs to them. There are no parents in evidence.

Two generations of Italians extricate themselves from a Fairmont. Papa is holding his wallet, like a broker. His sultry daughters and a suitor follow. Next comes a poorer family speaking Spanish. They are transparently window-shopping, since it doesn't cost to dream. This is what migration means, after all. This is the prize you most aspire to.

We follow them to Jennings, which has the biggest crowds. The salesmen look enthusiastic, like actors who have drawn a full house. "We're simply the best!" says Peter Curtis, who seems to

believe it. "We've been in the business 53 years, and we offer a 25-year guarantee. There's no other firm doing that! We've got fixed prices, the one-stop changeover! You got problems? We honor them! There was a bloke rang us the other week. He had a house put up 15 years ago, and he said the door was sticking. So what did we do? We went out and we fixed the door! We didn't have to, but we thought — Oh, what the hell! It's the kind of service we believe in!"

We decide we will buy the Parkville. Decision made, we get back in the car. The day is hotting up, with the steamy heat of early summer. We drive in streams of traffic through leafy Vermont and Warringa, past the joggers, fledgling gum trees, wide deep blocks, the satisfactory dream homes of the past 30 years. On the way is much related industry — shops like Festival or Sunshine Kitchens, the kind of euphemisms that make me long to start up Ratti Kitchens and Lousy Laundries by way of competition.

Blackburn Road, Templestowe, is a truly extraordinary sight. This is vintage dream-home country — not one or two estates, but Zebra Homes, Lucas Homes, Grollo Homes, Fasham Homes, Limmore, Merchant Builders, the catalogue flashing by! We came last summer, to Hemingway Estate. It was proclaimed by a huge billboard, with Papa Hemingway beaming improbably over bleached acres of long grass and glinting new roofs. We stop first at the Grollo Home, titled, with some narcissism, as the Grollingsone. It is an ethnic display home, a curious merging of Italianate with Spanish arches, and a vague touch of colonial. A thick-set, indifferent man looks up as we enter. Business is far from brisk — the house is absolutely empty.

There is patterned wallpaper with differently patterned tiles. In the livingroom cheap, drawn drapes obscure the view. There are arches in the upstairs bathroom, over the shower, over the bath. This is THE HOUSE THAT GROWS WITH YOUR FAMILY. The one next door is perfect for agoraphobics. It is literally blockaded, with a dark-brown iron grille over balcony, windows, and door.

Glen Waverley once looked like this — I remember it. Hills and dales as far as the eye could see with new tile roofs and bristling TV antennae.

We go to Merchant Builders, subtle homes that sink into their setting. These are pricey and classy, but time is short. We decide to end with something more ostentatious. We drive a kilometre back to Glenville, past the land sales and the spec houses.

The Glen V, the flagship of the range that sells (Basic) at \$153,900, stands on the crest of a hill. FOR YOUR SECURE INVESTMENT AND PEACE OF MIND IN A HOME WHICH OFFERS A TOTALLY NEW EXPERIENCE OF SPATIAL FLOW AND FORM, gushes the brochure. This was the 1984 industry House of the

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Look what they've done to our beer

DON'T you feel worried over what is happening to our beloved national drink.

For a start we are not drinking as much any more. Back in the rosy Whitlam era of 1974-75 we consumed nigh on 140 litres a head. Now in the more parched Hawkeian age we are down to 115 litres.

And look what has happened to our breweries. Our pioneers were so deeply devoted to the product that when they set up a town they did a number of important things: 1, build a racecourse; 2, a brewery; 3, a pub; and 4, a church.

In 1890 for example we had 350 breweries in Australia. Progressively they began to swallow one another, until now we are perilously close to having only two. Elders IXL, through Carlton United, is making 48 per cent of all the beer. Alan Bond, with the aid of Swan-Castlemaine-Toohy, is producing 42 per cent.

Admittedly there are a few other minor operations. There's the South Australian Brewing Company, 22 per cent owned by Elders. Then there's Cascade in Hobart owned by Ron Brierley of Industrial Equity Ltd. And there's Coopers in Adelaide, a small family operation.

Elders and Bond are fighting out a stubby-for-stubby battle to the

death. Elders is promoting itself through horses and the Foster's Cup. Bond through yachts, and it is just a matter of time before the America's Cup is known as the Bond Cup.

Carlton is waging an all-out campaign to establish Foster's as the national brand. Alan Bond has the problem in that he has three: Castlemaine, Tooheys and Swan. We have been watching fascinated to see what he will do for a national beer. Could he produce Castlemaine, Tooheys, or even Swooheymaine.

It looks as if he may have provided the answer. Last week he invaded Melbourne, the very frothing heart of the Foster empire, and had a grand launching of his new beer at the Regent in Collins Street: Swan Premium Export Lager, very upmarket, in black cans and black stubbies, to be known for ever more as the Black Swan.

There was a splendid video show with the theme: "Style is Back in Black." There were black BMWs, languorous beauties in black gowns, and black was all the go.

It must have frightened the hell out of Mr Bond's minions in Queensland, because Castlemaine has spent more than \$2 million trying to crack the Melbourne mar-



ket. Think of all those commercials. He had these romantic, beautifully photographed scenes of a brewery truck coming down the highway, bringing Castlemaine Aussie gold to dry Melbourne tongues.

So what happens now? Does Black Swan compete with Castlemaine, brother against brother, or does that Castlemaine truck now have to head back home.

OK, last night I conducted my own little beer-tasting. I bought a can of Black Swan and a can of the old Swan Lager. Fellow drinkers, I could not pick the slightest difference.

I bought a stubby of Melbourne Bitter and it was pretty hard to pick the difference there either.

Maybe the Swan was slightly more hoppy.

Next I fetched a can of Castlemaine Fourx. Glory be, blindfold me, turn me round, it could have been Swan.

The truth is that all our breweries have the one idea of the Australian taste. Remember when Courage came out here? It admitted that it set out to produce a beer as close to Foster's Lager as it could get. It certainly succeeded, but the only trouble was nobody would buy it.

Yes, they are all the same. One time I gathered half-a-dozen of our most sensitive beer palates at Lou Richards's pub, masked 24 Australian beers and asked the panel what they were.

Our brilliant experts were hopeless. They thought Tooheys was Courage, they thought Courage was Fourx, and so on. The only beer they actually identified was Coopers of Adelaide.

Curly Rorke, vigilance officer of the Waterside Workers Union, came out with the immortal line: "That's Coopers, cos it's been through the horse twice."

Since then I have conducted the experiment many times and it only gets harder. Australian beers are becoming closer in flavor than ever.

Ah, but there was a time when little towns had local breweries. The beer maybe was not as pure, not as hygienic, not as superbly made as it is now, but they all had their own local character. The breweries had interesting names like Phoenix, Shamrock, Emu, Eagle, Star, and there was even Mrs Eliza Crisp's brewery at Yarrowonga.

I reckon a Crisp pint in Yarrowonga would have been irresistible.

So if beer sales are falling while wine sales are on the forever up and up maybe the answer is for our barons to give us more variety in our beers.

Mr John Elliott, chief of Elders, is in a deep struggle to take over Allied-Lyons, the second largest brewing operation in Britain. Allied-Lyons is shocked, affronted, that a company a quarter its size, should attempt such a thing. There was a suggestion last week that it could even reverse the process and take over Elders.

Imagine what would happen then. The Poms would come out here and start serving their warm, flat, brown Pommie Ale.

If that happened we would really need to go hunting for Eliza Crisp.

— Keith Dunstan

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